Google Cybersecurity Professional Certificate

Incident Handler's Journal — Practical Exercise Report

Date / Time	October 10, 2026 | 09:00 AM EST
Entry #	Entry #1 (Initial Incident Documentation)
Description	Documenting a critical ransomware security incident at a US primary healthcare clinic.
Tools Used	None (Initial Incident Response Triage & Logging)

THE 5 W'S OF THE INCIDENT

- **Who:** An organized group of unethical cyber threat actors known for targeting healthcare and transportation sectors.
- **What:** A major ransomware security incident resulting in the encryption of critical corporate data and patient medical records.
- **Where:** A small primary healthcare clinic in the United States.
- **When:** Tuesday morning, approximately at 9:00 AM.
- **Why:** The attackers gained initial access via targeted phishing emails sent to several employees containing malicious attachments. Once downloaded, the payload executed and deployed ransomware. The primary motivation appears to be financial extortion, as a ransom note was displayed demanding a large sum in exchange for the decryption key.

ADDITIONAL NOTES & ANALYSIS

Key Incident Considerations & Questions:

- How did the malicious payload bypass existing email gateway security controls?
- What immediate steps must be taken to isolate affected workstations and prevent lateral movement across the healthcare network?
- Should the organization pay the ransom to retrieve critical patient records, or rely on offline secure backups?
- What employee security awareness training protocols should be implemented immediately to mitigate future phishing risks?